

שבועות of יום טוב always is the שבת before the שבועות. As an aside, my quiz question for everyone I've come into contact with for the last two weeks is, if the שבת before פסח is שבת הגדול and the שבת before יום כיפור is שבת שובה, what is the name of the שבת before שבועות? Everyone looks at me with a glazed look and I answer them שבת דרך ארץ because לתורה קדמה לתורה. It's in the חידושי הרי"ם.

But that is not the thrust of this week's talk. Many of the מפרשים, from ראשונים to אחרונים, as prominently as מגילה in תוספות, up to and including R' Moshe Feinstein, discuss the question: why is it specifically פרשת במדבר that comes before שבועות? We know that פרשת במדבר includes one of the counts, the census of בני ישראל. The second pasuk of the פרשה says: "בני ישראל - שָׂאוּ אֶת ראש כָּל עֵדֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל - Count up בני ישראל." All the מפרשים ask: why does it use the לשון of שָׂאוּ? It could have said מָנוּ, or used another term that simply means "count." But שָׂאוּ also means "to lift up." This teaches us that each and every Yid is equal in value. Each one is counted once. The person who has the least amount of knowledge, an עַם האָרֶץ, is counted equally with the greatest חכם תלמיד. This gives us an incentive to aspire to greatness, we should never think it's beyond us. Every one of us is an equal member of כלל ישראל. Therefore, R' Moshe says in דרש משה that the reason we read פרשת במדבר before שבועות is to remind us that we can lift ourselves up. The way to elevate ourselves is by receiving the תורה and to study it.

What's fascinating is at the beginning of the פרשה is this census, this counting of each and every member of כלל ישראל. And at the very end of what we read on פרשת במדבר, not the end of the פרשה itself, but the end of the הפטרה, which comes from הוֹשֵׁעַ in תרי עשר, there is a powerful conclusion. The last two פסוקים in the הפטרה of פרשת במדבר, which all boys who are 13 years and older will instantly recognize, are as follows: וְאַרְשָׁתִּיךָ לִי בְצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים - I will betroth you to me forever; וְאַרְשָׁתִּיךָ לִי לְעוֹלָם - I will betroth you with righteousness, with justice, with kindness, and with mercy. וְאַרְשָׁתִּיךָ לִי בְאֱמוּנָה - I will betroth you with faith; וְיָדַעְתָּ אֶת ה' - and then you will know Hashem. These פסוקים, which we say every day when we put on our תפילין - and if we're looking forward to our מצוה בר מצוה when we're not yet 13, we start learning it ahead of time - reflects the tremendous excitement, the enthusiasm, and the happiness we feel in drawing closer to Hashem, just like a חתן and כלה who are in the stage of אירוסין. The מפרשים explain that is why the pasuk uses אַרְשָׁתִּיךָ and not נִשְׁוֹאִין - because this is the period of anticipation. They're looking forward with enthusiasm to that happy day when they'll become a בית נאמן בישראל.

That is what הר סיני was. It is so appropriate that this is the שבת of במדבר, right before שבועות - to infuse us with that same excitement and enthusiasm. To inspire and energize us with the drive we should have, each and every year, and every day, as we anticipate the תורה הקדושה that Hashem is giving to us. We have the זכות to learn it, and through it, to come closer to Hashem. וְיָדַעְתָּ אֶת ה' - this knowledge of Hashem, ידיעת השם, is the ultimate goal of all of תורה.

This was my father's ע"ה bar mitzvah parsha, and this was his הפטרה. It's something which is so well known to us, which he had the זכות to have for his bar mitzvah parsha. My father was an inspiration to us all. His memory should be a ברכה, and he should be a מליץ יושר for all of כלל ישראל.

